ETABLIX

INTEGRATED SITE SERVICES

A trading name of JNN GLOBAL LTD · Company number 15405437

WORKING BRIEF

THE TRIGGER WATCH — WHAT IT IS, AND WHAT IT REFUSES TO BE

internal working document — not for issue to a client or a buyer

Document	The trigger watch — what it is, and what it refuses to be
Source	business/strategy/the-trigger-watch.md
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Built 17 October 2026, after the question: could ETABLIX have something that goes round the internet, finds company email addresses and sends them an automatic approach?

Technically, yes. Crawl pages, regex for addresses, send over SMTP. A few hundred lines and no third-party service needed. It was not built, and this records why, because the question will come back when money is short.

Why not the harvester

It would destroy the only channel the business runs on. *etablix.com* is a young domain with almost no sending history. Cold volume from it reaches spam traps and blocklists within days, and then nothing arrives: not the ILI follow-up, not the Mace introduction, not a supplier reply. Every careful letter written this month depends on the domain still being trusted. Domain reputation is slow to earn and fast to lose.

The legal position is narrower than it looks. Under PECR, marketing email to corporate subscribers — limited companies and LLPs — does not need prior consent, so business-to-business cold email is lawful in principle provided the sender is identified and opt-outs are honoured. Three things then bite. Sole traders and ordinary partnerships count as individual subscribers and need consent. A named work address is personal data under the UK GDPR even though the company is not a person. And Article 14 obliges anyone who collects personal data from somewhere other than the person to tell them where it came from, normally within a month — answerable for ten people and dishonest at any scale a crawler reaches.

And it contradicts what works. The replies that landed this month landed because they had evidently been written by somebody who read the other side's material. An automated blast is recognisable in one line.

What was built instead

A watcher that finds **moments, not addresses**: the point at which a scheme has just become somebody's problem and nobody has answered it yet. Consent granted. Main contractor appointed. Project transferred to an owner. Financial close. A workforce large enough to need housing.

It queues what it finds, with the evidence and the published route in. **A person reads the queue, writes the approach and sends it from their own mailbox.** Nothing is sent by the machine, and nothing in it can send.

Part	Where
Polite fetching: robots.txt, rate limits, conditional requests	backend/lib/signals/fetch.js
The published contact route, and the personal-data gate	backend/lib/signals/contact.js
Triggers, deduplication, suppression, the sweep	backend/lib/signals/index.js
The reading queue	backend/routes/signals.js
Sources, edited without a deploy	content/signals/sources.json
Source health check	backend/tools/signals-check.mjs
Runs on the existing sweep as rule signal_watch	backend/lib/automation.js

The three rules, and why each is a test rather than a comment

robots.txt is obeyed and hosts are rate limited. Consulted before the request, never after. One request per host at a time, never faster than the host's own Crawl-delay and never faster than five seconds. A host whose

robots.txt cannot be read is treated as closed rather than open. Ignoring robots.txt is not a shortcut; it is a company deciding other people's stated wishes do not apply to it, which is a strange position for one that sells accountability.

No personal email address is ever stored. Role addresses only, from a closed allowlist — a local part containing a dot, a plus or a digit is personal by definition, so *j.smith@*, *jsmith2@* and *info.john@* are all discarded. Everything written passes through one scrubbing function that also strips raw page text, so a change elsewhere cannot start persisting personal data without that function being changed, and changing it fails the build.

The suppression list cannot be overridden. It is checked inside the only function that writes to the queue, and again when a signal is marked approached — so something queued before a suppression existed still cannot be acted on. There is no API route to remove a suppression: taking a name off a do-not-contact list should cost a database edit and a moment's thought, not a button.

And a fourth, structural. There is no transport anywhere in the module, and the test asserts there is none. The moment a watcher can also send, it becomes the thing it was built instead of.

Using it

Sources ship **disabled**, because a URL invented at build time is a 404 at run time, and a watcher quietly fetching nothing looks exactly like a quiet market.

- **1.** Edit *content/signals/sources.json*. An RSS or Atom feed works far better than a listing page. Add the organisation's own supplier or contact page as *contactPage* and the watcher will find the published route in.
- **2.** Check the URL in a browser, then set *enabled: true*.
- **3.** Run *node backend/tools/signals-check.mjs*. It says which sources answer, which are barred by robots.txt, which have moved, and how many items would queue today.
- **4.** The automation sweep runs it from then on. Signals scoring five or more raise one notification every twelve hours.

Start with the sources already known to matter. The acquirers that buy ILI schemes announce transfers by press release. Main contractor appointments are carried by the trade press. Section 36 and DCO decisions are published. Those are three real feeds and worth more than thirty speculative ones.

The honest expectation

This does not produce customers. It produces **ten well-aimed approaches a week instead of one**, and it removes the hour a day that finding them costs. The conversion still depends on the letter, and the letter still has to be written by the person who will answer the telephone afterwards.